

Body language

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Body language forms an outsized part of an interviewer's overall impression, often within the first minute — well before a single technical question is asked. A firm handshake, upright posture, and appropriate eye contact create a positive first impression that a strong answer later must live up to; conversely, a slouched entrance or a limp handshake can put an interviewer on the back foot even against a candidate's own intentions. This sub-module covers the specific, controllable components of interview body language: entering the room, sitting posture, eye contact norms, gesture and stillness, and the distinct considerations for video interviews (camera framing, background, and the loss of some physical cues), along with how to read an interviewer's own body language for cues about how an answer is landing.

1. First Impressions: Entry, Handshake, and Greeting

The first 10-15 seconds — entering the room, greeting, and sitting down — disproportionately shape an interviewer's initial impression, often called the primacy effect. A firm (not crushing) handshake with eye contact and a genuine greeting ('Good morning, thank you for having me') sets a confident tone; a limp or overly aggressive handshake, or avoiding eye contact during the greeting, undercuts it immediately. Waiting to be told where to sit, rather than sitting down uninvited, is a small but noticed courtesy. In a video interview, the equivalent 'entry' is a clear, warm verbal greeting and a visible smile since a handshake isn't possible.

2. Sitting Posture Throughout the Interview

Sitting upright with a slight forward lean signals engagement without appearing stiff or overly rigid; slouching back reads as disinterest, while sitting bolt upright and unmoving for the entire interview can look tense rather than composed. Feet flat on the floor and hands resting visibly (on the table, on your lap, or gesturing naturally) are the default safe posture; crossed arms, even when comfortable rather than defensive, are widely read as closed-off and are worth consciously avoiding.

- Comfortable, engaged posture: shoulders relaxed, slight forward lean when the interviewer is speaking, hands visible and available for natural gesture.
- Avoid: crossed arms, hands hidden under the table throughout, or leaning back with an overly casual, sprawled posture.

3. Eye Contact Norms

Consistent, natural eye contact signals confidence and honesty in most professional interview contexts (norms vary somewhat across cultures, but this is the dominant expectation in most corporate interview settings). The practical target is holding eye contact for a few seconds at a time, breaking briefly and naturally (to the side, not down at your hands or the table, which can read as evasive) rather than either staring fixedly or avoiding eye contact almost entirely. With a multi-person panel, distributing eye contact across all interviewers as you answer — not just the one who asked — signals that you're addressing the whole panel.

4. Hand Gestures and Stillness

Natural hand gestures while explaining a point (within the space roughly between shoulders and waist) make delivery feel more animated and genuine; keeping hands rigidly still in your lap for an entire interview can look tense. The opposite extreme — large, frequent gestures, or fidgeting with a pen, hair, or clothing — is distracting and reads as nervous energy. A useful check: if a gesture is naturally supporting what you're saying (indicating size, counting points on fingers, an open-palm gesture while explaining), it's helpful; if it's repetitive and disconnected from content (tapping, clicking, touching your face repeatedly), it's a nervous habit worth actively reducing.

5. Reading the Interviewer's Body Language

Body language is also a two-way signal — noticing an interviewer's cues helps calibrate your answer in real time. An interviewer leaning forward, nodding, or maintaining engaged eye contact suggests your answer is landing well and can continue at the current depth; an interviewer glancing at their notes, checking the time, or leaning back with a neutral expression is a cue to wrap up the current point more quickly rather than continuing to elaborate. This kind of real-time calibration is a subtle but genuine communication skill, not something to obsess over to the point of distraction.

6. Video Interview Specifics

Video interviews remove some physical cues (a handshake, full-body posture) but introduce new body-language considerations: camera framing (positioning the camera at eye level rather than looking down into a laptop camera, which is unflattering and reads as disengaged), looking at the camera lens periodically rather than only at the screen (looking at the screen feels natural to you but looks like you're avoiding the interviewer's 'eyes' on their end), and a plain, tidy background that doesn't distract from you. Lighting facing you (not behind you, which silhouettes your face) and a stable internet connection are practical prerequisites that, when missing, distract from body language entirely regardless of how good it otherwise is.

- Position the laptop/camera at eye level using a stack of books if needed — a low camera angle looking up your face reads poorly.

- Glance at the camera lens (not just the screen) periodically when speaking, to simulate eye contact for the interviewer.

7. Nervous Tics and How to Reduce Them

Common nervous tics — repetitive leg bouncing, pen clicking, touching your face or hair, looking down frequently — are usually invisible to the person doing them but very noticeable to an observer, which is exactly why they're hard to self-correct without deliberate practice. Recording a mock interview on video and watching it back is the most effective way to spot your own specific tics, since different people have different default nervous habits. Once identified, a simple physical counter-habit (e.g., consciously resting hands on the table rather than in your lap, where fidgeting is less visible on camera but still present) can reduce a specific tic significantly with a few sessions of conscious practice.

Common Pitfalls

- A limp handshake or avoiding eye contact during the initial greeting, undercutting the first impression immediately.
- Crossed arms or a slouched posture that unintentionally signals disinterest or defensiveness.
- Staring fixedly at one panelist in a multi-interviewer panel instead of distributing eye contact.
- Looking down at hands or notes repeatedly instead of breaking eye contact naturally to the side.
- In video interviews, looking only at the screen rather than periodically at the camera lens, which reads as avoiding eye contact.
- A low, upward-angled camera in a video interview, which looks unflattering and disengaged.
- Repetitive nervous tics (pen-clicking, leg-bouncing, face-touching) that go unnoticed by the candidate but are obvious to the interviewer.

Key Takeaways

- The first 10-15 seconds — handshake, greeting, sitting down — disproportionately shape the interviewer's first impression.
- Sit upright with a slight forward lean; avoid both slouching and rigid over-stiffness.
- Break eye contact naturally to the side, never down, and distribute it across a multi-person panel.
- Natural gestures support your speech; repetitive fidgeting distracts from it — know the difference.
- In video interviews, camera at eye level and periodic glances at the lens simulate real eye contact.
- Record yourself in mock interviews to catch nervous tics you can't feel in the moment.

Learn More

Indeed — Body Language Tips for a Job Interview

<https://www.indeed.com/career-advice/interviewing/interview-body-language>

Harvard Business Review — Connect, Then Lead

<https://hbr.org/2013/07/connect-then-lead>

MindTools — Body Language

<https://www.mindtools.com/aoin4y7/body-language>